

The “Dead Theory” of Content: Investigating the psychological and economic impact of an internet increasingly populated by AI-generated content rather than human-created data

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Abstract - With regard to the rapid development of artificial intelligence (AI), especially in relation to technologies for generating digital content like LLMs, the internet's content creation processes have become much more complicated than they were before. One version of internet development, commonly referred to as the Dead Theory of Content, claims that nowadays most internet content is not generated by people but by computers and bots that use AI models. This paper aims to analyze how much AI is affecting the internet, what changes in authenticity, information, and social life result from that, and whether the Dead Theory of Content makes sense or not. Based on the data regarding bot activities, the prevalence of automation in social media usage, the rise of content farming, and new developments in LLMs, the study will discuss whether the future of the internet belongs to machines, and also provide solutions to address some issues posed by this phenomenon.

Keywords – Dead Internet Theory, Generated Content, GPTs (Generative Trained Transformers)

With the rise of generative artificial intelligence that is able to create realistic-looking text, pictures, and videos, the rules of content creation on the internet have changed dramatically. Such instruments enable the generation of numerous pieces of content within a short period of time with little effort and costs, making them extremely valuable to various organizations and marketing companies.

Dead Theory of Content states that the web will be filled with computer-generated content and less authentic human activity. The content shared on the internet, such as social media messages, news, etc., is either machine-made or is influenced heavily by them. Hence, there arise some issues about the fate of the Internet and its future. Will it remain a platform of authentic human creativity or will become a playground for computers?

This paper is an attempt to evaluate the theory in a critical perspective.

I. INTRODUCTION

Traditionally, the internet was built as an instrument for communication among humans, collaboration, and sharing knowledge. Since the emergence of web forums, blogs, and modern social networks, the role of people in creating the digital ecosystem was critical. Nevertheless, the rapid development of artificial intelligence in recent years has brought about changes in the way content is generated and consumed online.

II. BACKGROUND

The "Dead Internet Theory" emerged from the internet itself, through discussions and analyses that the internet is not as much human-driven anymore as previously believed. Initially seen as an outlandish theory, the notion seems to be gaining credibility based on observable patterns in cyberspace.

One of the reasons behind the theory could be the rise of bots. These are software programs that can post messages, communicate with people, and scrape data. Although most bots are useful, there are also malicious bots that manipulate interactions, propagate disinformation, and inflate metrics.

Another key reason is the emergence of content generated by machines. Due to progress in machine learning technology, it is now possible for machines to create texts, images, and videos, which are hard to differentiate from those generated by humans. Such technologies are extensively applied in fields such as marketing, journalism, and entertainment.

Moreover, the use of algorithms on platform websites emphasizes high engagement levels. As a result, content that gets more engagement irrespective of its nature is preferred by many platforms.

These processes are creating a context in which it becomes harder to tell whether content is written by a machine or human being, thus supporting the relevance of the Dead Theory of Content.

III. PROBLEM STATEMENT

The rise of content generated by AI and automated processes poses some serious threats to the quality of our digital ecosystem. Firstly, human interaction is declining. With machines now responsible for producing content, there could soon be a lack of true human voices in the digital space.

Secondly, the issue of misinformation has risen sharply. Machines have the capability to produce misleading yet convincing information, which malicious parties could use to influence people's opinions.

Thirdly, differentiating between humans and artificial intelligence has become increasingly difficult over time due to the advancements made by AI models. There is a lack of ways that can be used in order to identify fake identities.

Lastly, the use of automated methods can enable the creation of discourses in politics and society. By creating an impression of acceptance or dissent, the discourse can be amplified through the use of bots. The above-mentioned issues clearly show the significance of developing an improved understanding of the role of AI in content creation.

IV. LITERATURE REVIEW

A lot of academic work has been conducted on the impact of artificial intelligence generated content and bots in the digital environment. Studies conducted on the AI generated content deal mainly with their efficiency and effectiveness as AI can produce huge amounts of information while consuming less of human effort. The studies conducted on the bots have revealed that bots constitute a huge portion of internet traffic. The bots are ranging from simple computer codes to highly advanced forms of AI which can mimic human behavior.

AI-based botnets can engage themselves in collective action which creates realistic user interactions. Such botnets can help in spreading fake news, manipulations of trends, and shaping public opinion.

Apart from that, the studies related to algorithmic content distribution have revealed that social media sites prefer to emphasize engagement rather than the authenticity of the content. Therefore, fake content is gaining more attention. Although some valuable contributions were made by those studies, yet further study is required in this field.

V. SIGNIFICANCE OF THE STUDY

It is essential to mention that the present research is significant because it focuses on addressing one of the most critical problems in contemporary times – the contradiction between technology and humans. By studying the theory of dead content, it is possible to understand the impact of artificial intelligence on the interactions taking place online. While revealing the negative sides of excessive automation, the research also takes into account the benefits that can be derived from artificial intelligence. The findings of the research can serve as a basis for developing approaches to ensure trust and humanness in the digital environment.

VI. ROLE OF AI IN TODAY'S WORLD

AI is a constituent element of contemporary life that operates in various aspects of our everyday existence. In regard to content creation, there are several pros and cons associated with using artificial intelligence.

A. Pros of AI

One of the primary benefits of AI for content creation is increased productivity. Companies can now create content much faster and at a lower cost than before. Besides, thanks to such innovations as translation, voice recognition, and summarization, the use of AI improves content accessibility.

B. *Cons of AI*

On the contrary, there are several problems with using AI for content creation. Firstly, when relying on AI, people may lose their originality. Besides, artificial intelligence opens up possibilities for creating false information on a massive scale. These opportunities can be used to manipulate people's opinions or even create propaganda. Another significant drawback is the possibility of experiencing echo chambers – only one point of view will dominate your news feed.

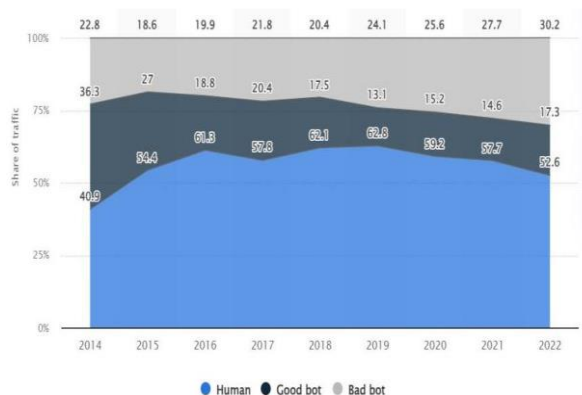


Fig 1. Distribution of bot and human web traffic worldwide from 2014 to 2022

VII. CRITICISM

Though it has gained much popularity recently, the concept of the Dead Theory of Content has received considerable criticism by researchers and professionals working in the industry.

First of all, one of the most common criticisms is related to the absence of concrete evidence proving the assumption about the dominance of machine-generated material on the internet. Even though AI has significantly increased in use, there is still a lot of

content produced by humans. Secondly, AI tends to be an aid for many content creators rather than something that replaces human creativity and effort. Lastly, the theory is considered to be very pessimistic as it does not provide enough information about the possible benefits of AI.

VIII. EVIDENCE

A. *Bot Traffic*

According to several studies, there exists a significant percentage of internet traffic that is created by bots. Bots have multiple roles in different processes, ranging from positive operations like indexing in search engines to malicious actions such as spamming and committing cyber fraud.

B. *Social Media Manipulation*

Social media sites are highly prone to bot-related actions. Bots may be used to create fake accounts and engage in various activities to make certain types of content look more attractive than others.

C. *Generation of Content by AI*

With the introduction of the new generation of artificial intelligence technologies, the amount of content being produced with the help of AI technologies has sharply increased. There is a growing amount of content generated by AI on websites and social media networks.

D. *Distil Networks 2019 Bad Bot Report*

In the Bad Bot Report from Distil Networks released in 2019, there was recognition of the increasing complexity of bots and how they affect internet traffic. It was evident that bots were becoming increasingly complex and difficult to detect.

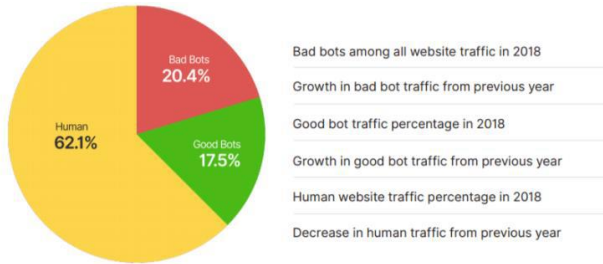


Figure 2: Bad Bots vs. Good Bots vs. Human Traffic 2018. Bots drove nearly 40% of internet traffic last year

IX. AI AND CONTENT FARMING

Content farms are involved in creating mass quantities of digital content, seeking the maximum number of clicks and profits through the process. The advancement of AI has been instrumental in increasing the speed of content creation. AI-enabled content farms create content in bulk in the form of written articles, videos, and social media posts. However, this creates a problem since the focus is on creating large amounts of content irrespective of its quality.

Additionally, content farms use the algorithms in platforms to their advantage by producing content that is highly engaging.

Top 5 Bad Bot Traffic by Country

1	United States	53.4%
2	Netherlands	5.7%
3	China	3.9%
4	Germany	3.9%
5	Canada	3.2%

Top 5 Most Blocked Country

1	Russia
2	Ukraine
3	India
4	China
5	United States

Figure3. Comparing Top 5 Countries That Contribute to Bad Bot Traffic with the Top 5 Mostly Blocked Countries Shows Differences between the Real and Perceived Origins of Dangerous Traffic

X. CHALLENGES & RISKS

Some of the problems that arise because of AI-generated content are:

- Detection of AI-generated content is difficult
- Misinformation is likely to be spread more often
- Ethical considerations regarding ownership and authenticity
- Poor content because of feedback loops

XI. PROPOSED SOLUTIONS

As a result of the growing interest in AI-generated content, the value and existence of human-generated content have significantly reduced. This phenomenon is referred to as the Dead Theory of Content in this study. Furthermore, this phenomenon raises numerous questions regarding originality and authenticity, and therefore, it is crucial to develop a novel strategy to counter these problems.

1. Artificial Intelligence Based Content Detection System

In the research paper, there will be an explanation of the AI content detection system that can detect whether content is written by machine or by a person using a hybrid approach.

The system uses DistilGPT2 framework for measuring the value of the perplexity metric, which measures text unpredictability. Low values of the metric indicate machine creation, while large variances may suggest human writing.

The results are provided as:

- Probability of artificial intelligence
- Probability of humans
- Classification result
- Linguistic interpretation

2. Strengths of the system

There are several advantages that allow addressing some of the limitations related to the Dead Theory of Content:

- Hybrid Detection Strategy
Involves using both deep learning and statistics (transformer and entropy-based statistical)

techniques so that there is no dependency on only one technique.

- Fallback Strategy
If the transformer technique is not available, the system can resort to statistical techniques based on entropy.
- Multi-dimensional Strategy
This strategy differs from others because it involves studying different language components instead of focusing on one aspect.

3. Identified Limitations in Current Implementation

Despite its contributions, the current system has several limitations:

- Synthesis of Training Data
The classifier is based on very small synthetic data created by hand. It prevents generalization and may be biased because it does not cover realistic content variety.
- Simpler Model
The application of logistic regression limits the model's capacity to capture non-linear dependencies between language features.
- Small Context Window
The transformer-based model takes only up to 1024 tokens into consideration, which might decrease the accuracy of analysis of long texts.
- Real-World Validation Absence
The system was not validated on large datasets containing AI-written and human-written content.

4. Proposed enhancements

To improve system performance and scalability, the following enhancements are recommended:

- Real World Datasets Integration:
Employing various kinds of datasets starting from real-world to synthetic datasets such as ChatGPT outputs to improve accuracy.

- High-end Machine Learning Techniques:

Abandonment of Logistic Regression algorithm and implementation of high-end machine learning techniques like Random Forest or Neural Network.

5. Hybrid Verification Framework

A hybrid model of verification is suggested to improve the effectiveness of detecting errors. The suggested model involves:

- The use of automated tools for initial mass analysis
- Human verification of marginal cases

The above process will ensure scalability without compromising on context sensitivity.

XII. CONCLUSION

The Dead Theory of Content presents an interesting viewpoint on how the internet continues to change over time. Although one could argue that the internet is not dead at all, the growth of AI content and its associated challenges must be acknowledged, as it presents numerous issues regarding authenticity. This paper demonstrates the importance of approaching the problem from multiple perspectives in order to utilize both advantages and disadvantages of AI. With proper implementation and use of technology, it will be possible to preserve integrity and continue interacting with other people online.

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